CHOCOLATE STRAWBERRY MOUSSE

Eggless • Gelatin-free recipe • Crispy chocolate-feuilletine base

Yield: 6 individual mousse domes **Skill level:** Intermediate

Texture: airy chocolate mousse, a small fresh strawberry piece in the centre, a delicate crisp chocolate base, and a thin glossy chocolate shell.

Important: This version uses a small piece of fresh strawberry inside each mousse dome. The crunchy base is biscuit-sized (about 3–4 cm across).

Recipe overview

- Prepare the mini crispy chocolate discs first and allow them to set.
- Make the chocolate mousse and fill the silicone half-sphere moulds.
- Embed a small strawberry piece in the centre and seal it with mousse.
- Add the crunchy disc as the base, freeze until firm, then unmould and coat.
- Refrigerate until thawed before serving for the best mousse texture.

All quantities are in grams for accuracy. Use a digital kitchen scale wherever possible.

1. Ingredients

A. Crispy chocolate-feuilletine discs (makes 6 small discs)

Ingredient	Quantity	Notes
Dark couverture chocolate	70 g	About 55–70% cocoa
Hazelnut praline paste	35 g	Smooth paste
Feuilletine flakes	45 g	Thin, crisp pastry flakes
Fine salt	0.5 g	Optional, balances sweetness

B. Eggless chocolate mousse

Ingredient	Quantity	Notes
Dark couverture chocolate	180 g	Finely chopped
Heavy cream, for ganache	100 g	Preferably 35% fat
Whole milk	40 g	Warm with the cream
Heavy cream, for whipping	250 g	Very cold, 35% fat preferred
Vanilla extract	3 g	Optional
Fine salt	0.5 g	Optional

C. Strawberry centre (fresh fruit version)

Ingredient	Quantity	Notes
Fresh firm strawberry	6 small pieces	One 1–1.5 cm piece per dome; pat dry

D. Thin chocolate coating

Ingredient	Quantity	Notes
Dark couverture chocolate	180 g	For tempering
Cocoa butter	20 g	Helps make a thinner coating; optional

Equipment: digital scale, small bowls, spatula, whisk, silicone half-sphere mould with 6 cavities, parchment paper, small round cutter or template (3–4 cm), piping bag or spoon, wire rack, thermometer (recommended), and a sharp knife.

2. Detailed Method

Step 1 — Make the mini crispy chocolate discs

- Melt the 70 g dark chocolate gently in short microwave bursts or over a water bath. Stir often; avoid getting any water into the chocolate.
- Stir in the hazelnut praline paste and salt until smooth.
- Let the mixture cool slightly until fluid but not hot. Fold in the feuilletine flakes gently with a spatula so the delicate flakes stay crisp.
- Place six small portions on parchment paper. Shape each into a neat, thin round disc about 3–4 cm in diameter and roughly 3–4 mm thick. Use the back of a spoon or a small round template to keep the edges tidy.
- Leave at cool room temperature until firm, or refrigerate briefly. Keep the discs flat and dry until assembly.

Chef's cue: The mixture should hold together when pressed but still show delicate flakes. If it is too runny, let it cool a little before shaping.

Step 2 — Prepare the chocolate ganache base

- Place the 180 g finely chopped dark chocolate in a heatproof bowl.
- Heat 100 g cream with 40 g milk until steaming, not vigorously boiling. Pour over the chocolate and leave undisturbed for 1 minute.
- Stir slowly from the centre outward until the mixture becomes smooth, glossy, and emulsified. Add vanilla and salt.
- Cool the ganache to approximately 35–38°C before adding whipped cream. If it is too hot, it can melt the cream; if too cold, it can become thick and difficult to fold.

Step 3 — Whip and fold the mousse

- Whip the 250 g cold cream to soft peaks. The whisk should leave trails, and the peak should bend over gently rather than stand stiff.
- Fold about one-third of the whipped cream into the cooled ganache to lighten it.
- Add the remaining cream in two additions. Use a broad spatula to cut down through the centre, sweep along the bowl, and fold over. Rotate the bowl as you work; stop as soon as no large white streaks remain.
- The finished mousse should be smooth, airy, and pipeable. Do not whisk vigorously after adding the cream.

Step 4 — Fill moulds and add the strawberry

- Pipe or spoon mousse into each silicone half-sphere cavity. Push some mousse up the sides to reduce air pockets, leaving a small cavity in the centre.
- Prepare six small fresh strawberry pieces, each about 1–1.5 cm wide. Choose firm fruit and pat each piece thoroughly dry with paper towel.
- Place one strawberry piece into the centre of each mousse cavity. Keep it surrounded by mousse rather than resting it on the surface.
- Cover the strawberry completely with more mousse and smooth the top. Avoid leaving the fruit exposed, as exposed fruit can release moisture and affect the finish.

Step 5 — Add the crispy base and freeze

- Place one mini chocolate-feuilletine disc flat on the exposed mousse surface of each mould. Press very gently so it sits level and makes contact without being pushed deeply into the mousse.
- Scrape away excess mousse around the edges for a clean finish.
- Freeze the moulds until the domes are completely firm, usually at least 6 hours and preferably overnight. Do not rely on a short chill; the domes must be frozen solid to unmould cleanly.

Step 6 — Unmould and coat

- Prepare the coating: melt the 180 g dark chocolate with the 20 g cocoa butter, stirring until smooth. For the best snap and shine, temper the chocolate mixture according to the chocolate manufacturer's instructions.

- Unmould the mousse domes while fully frozen and place them on a wire rack over a tray.
- When the coating is fluid and at a suitable working temperature for your chocolate, pour a thin, even layer over each frozen dome. Work quickly and avoid repeated pouring over the same area, which can create a thick shell.
- Allow excess chocolate to drip away. Transfer the domes carefully to a serving tray before the coating fully sets.

Step 7 — Thaw, plate, and serve

- Refrigerate the coated domes for approximately 3–4 hours, or until the mousse is thawed through but still cold. Timing depends on dome size and refrigerator temperature.
- For a clean cross-section, warm a sharp knife under hot water, wipe it completely dry, and cut in one smooth motion. Wipe and rewarm the knife between cuts.
- Serve cold. The ideal bite should combine a thin chocolate shell, airy mousse, a small juicy strawberry centre, and a crisp chocolate-feuilletine base.

3. Troubleshooting & Chef’s Notes

Problem	Likely cause	Fix
Mousse looks dense	Cream overwhipped or folded too aggressively	Whip only to soft peaks and fold gently.
Ganache turns grainy	Overheated chocolate or poor emulsion	Use warm—not boiling—dairy and stir from the centre outward.
Crunch disc becomes soft	Moisture migration from mousse or storage humidity	Keep discs dry; assemble and serve promptly after thawing.
Strawberry leaks juice	Fruit too ripe, wet, or cut too large	Use firm fruit, pat dry, and keep the piece small and fully enclosed.
Dome breaks on unmoulding	Not frozen solid or mould pulled too forcefully	Freeze longer and peel silicone away gently.
Chocolate shell too thick	Coating too cool or poured repeatedly	Adjust working temperature and use one smooth pour.

Storage and food safety

- Keep finished mousse domes refrigerated at 4°C or below and serve within 24 hours for best texture, especially because fresh strawberry is enclosed inside.
- Do not leave dairy-based mousse at room temperature for more than 2 hours; reduce this time in very hot conditions.
- The crunchy base softens gradually in contact with mousse. For the crispest result, serve the same day the domes are thawed.
- This recipe is eggless and uses no gelatin. Check couverture, praline, and feuilletine labels for allergen and vegetarian suitability.

The Curly Chef — precise technique, beautiful texture, unforgettable desserts.